

A Meaner Tuner

Q I have an Intel 1.1 GHz Pentium III with 256 MB of RAM and an 80 GB hard drive, along with a Tech-Com TV-Tuner. When I try to capture a TV program, it drops too many frames.

Ankit Sarang

A The system configuration you have is more than enough to view TV using a TV tuner. But it is not enough to record live TV at high quality. You will be able to record in the MPEG-1 format (VCD quality) without dropping a frame,

but if you try to record in MPEG-2 format (DVD quality), you will drop a lot of frames (the resultant captured file will be of poor quality). If you want to record in MPEG-2, consider upgrading your hardware to at least a 2 GHz Intel processor or a 2000+ processor from AMD. To capture in MPEG-2 with a really good quality, you will require a TV-Tuner card with hardware MPEG capture capability, such as those from Leadtek Winfast. Check out the TV-Tuner comparison test in our April 2007 issue for more details about TV-Tuners.

your CPU is compatible with the motherboard you might upgrade to.

Talk Unlimited

Q What is VoIP, and software for it is available in the market? I have heard that one can call for free through VoIP anywhere in India and abroad. Is that true? I have a broadband connection. I have a 1.5 GHz processor and 256 MB of RAM, and I use Windows XP. Do I have to reconfigure my system for dialling abroad?

Tahir Hussain

A VoIP stands for Voice Over Internet Protocol. It is a form of telephony that involves the routing of voice calls over an IP-based network (such as the Internet), thus making cheaper call rates possible. There are no providers offering free calls to India, but a few VoIP providers such as Globe7 at www.globe7.com, VoipBuster at www.voipbuster.com, and Gizmogear at www.gizmo-project.com allow you to call free to certain destinations, but only after you pay for a minimum amount of credit.

The minimum system requirements usually quoted by VoIP providers is a computer running Windows 2000/XP/Vista with a 300 MHz processor, 128 MB RAM, 10 MB free hard drive space, a full-duplex sound card, a headset, and at least a 64 Kbps Internet connection. You should have no problems with your configuration as far as VoIP is concerned. It does not require any special hardware. All you need to do is download the VoIP software client from the above Web sites, buy credit, and start calling.

Run Fun

Q Each drive on a friend's Windows XP computer has a unique icon, and a certain program runs when he double-clicks on them in My Computer. I am fascinated! How I can achieve this on my PC?

Yogesh Bhuskute

A The icon displayed for each drive in My Computer is due to the presence of an Autorun.inf in the root of the drive. This is exactly the same as in the case of the autorun feature of a CD or DVD. Autorun.inf is an instruc-

tion file associated with the Autorun function. A simple autorun.inf file looks like so:

```
[autorun]
open=autorun.exe
icon=autorun.ico
```

Here, autorun.exe is the executable file that is launched when the CD is inserted, and autorun.ico is the icon file that gives the CD its icon. In case of a disk partition, this file executes when you double-click the drive icon in My Computer. Sometimes an executable file or a DLL that might contain an icon is also used instead of an icon file.

You can also try a freeware Autorun file editor such as the one from <http://autorun.moon-valley.com> if you wish to play around with autorun files.

How Do I Tell?

Q I recently bought a PC with Windows XP Professional SP2 from a local PC assembler. He says the Windows is legal and is pre-activated. Please tell me how I can ascertain as to whether I have a legal and pre-activated copy of Windows.

Mayur Patel

A To check whether your Windows XP is already activated, open the Run dialog box, enter `oobe/msoobe /a` and click OK. If your copy is activated, you will be greeted with a "Thank you" screen; if not, you will be prompted to activate Windows.

To ascertain whether your copy of Windows XP was legally purchased, use Microsoft's online validation process: try to download any of the Genuine Windows downloads from the Microsoft Download Center. You will be prompted to validate your copy online; simply follow the instructions and you will be able to verify within a couple of minutes whether your copy of Windows is legal. For more information about this, go to www.microsoft.com/resources/howtotell/ to learn about how to tell whether a Microsoft product is legal or pirated.

Back To Square One

Q My Windows XP computer is in a bad state, and after searching for all possible solutions, I've found that reinstalling Windows is the only way out. Please explain the process of reinstalling Windows—many people like me are afraid to try it because of the fear of losing data.

Parag Shah

A You are right—sometimes the only solution is to reinstall XP. Actually, this is better



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